

« We overcomplicate things by bowling too many types of deliveries in one over »

TRENT BOULT

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Trent Boult adjusts his cap, puts his phone in his pocket, and says with a smile, "I always try to come into the IPL with an open mind of trying to get better."

Having transitioned to freelancing from his central contract with New Zealand Cricket to spend more time with family, Boult finds himself constantly on the move due to cricket commitments worldwide. Despite "dying to see" his three young boys, he remains passionate about the game.

Currently playing for the Rajasthan Royals in the IPL, he is gearing up for the T20 World Cup with New Zealand in June, followed by the Major Cricket League. Juggling these commitments is a challenge, but his love for bowling and competing against the best keeps him going.

In a chat with *Sportstar* in Jaipur, he reflects on his career and the impact of T20 cricket on fast bowlers.

It has been quite a satisfying campaign for the Rajasthan Royals so far. What are your thoughts?

It has been a great start. We won the first four games; I don't think we could have asked for a better beginning. The team is working together well, and we understand

that it's a long tournament. We had a good start last year too, so we're not looking too far ahead. We're just going to be ourselves at the moment.

As the most experienced fast bowler in the Rajasthan Royals team, how do you pass on your knowledge to the young players?

I think I offer a level of experience, since this is technically my 10th IPL. My first IPL was in 2015 for the Sunrisers Hyderabad. I was so excited because I had the opportunity to open the bowling with Dale Steyn, someone I never thought I would play against, let alone with.

I think that's the best part of this competition: it gives you the chance to bowl with bowlers you're not used to, bowlers you've played against, and then obviously inspire, coach, and mentor young bowlers coming through.

I've had the honour of bowling with a lot of great bowlers throughout my years: (Kagiso) Rabada, (Jasprit) Bumrah, and Steyn, to name a few. And then I moved to Rajasthan; there have been some brilliant up-and-coming bowlers who have represented India over the last couple of years. Then there's a nice balance with a guy like Sandy

(Sandeep) Sharma, who has played a lot of cricket. He debuted in the IPL in 2013, which was a long time ago. They all offer a lot of experience. I always try to come into these tournaments with an open mind, trying to get better, learn, and answer questions from any bowler.

This year, it's been exciting. We've got a find in Mr. Burger (Nandre Burger), as we call him, who is backed up nicely by Avesh Khan, who I have played with before. The spinners (Ravichandran Ashwin and Yuzvendra Chahal) need no description or introduction, so it's a nice balance.

Do you think that T20 cricket, with its cap of only four overs, has given a fresh lease of life to fast bowlers in terms of longevity?

No, I don't think that way, to be honest. Jimmy Anderson aside, I don't think anyone can get close to what he's achieved over his 20-something-odd career. He's an inspiration to every fast bowler out there. He does the yards, has played 20 years of Test cricket, and has claimed 700 wickets for a reason.

When it comes to the T20 format, apart from the obvious advantage of being a shorter format, I think it's still a very demanding game. With the amount of franchise cricket around